

FILM DOSSIER: GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY: THE THANOS IMPERATIVE

Phase 5 · Film #3 (Saga Two, Film #12 · Overall Film #41)

Status:  DOSSIER COMPLETE (awaiting showrunner lock)

1. IDENTITY

Field	Entry
Film #	Saga Two #12 (Phase 5, Film #3) · MCU #41
Phase	Phase 5, The Secret Wars Saga : "Time Runs Out"
Real title	<i>GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY: THE THANOS IMPERATIVE</i> (the 616 event)
Decoy / codename title	<i>"MIXTAPE III"</i>
Release date	Friday, November 7, 2025
Distributor	Walt Disney Studios Motion Pictures
Director	Joe Cornish (<i>James Gunn is running DC Studios, per real history</i>)
Rating / runtime	PG-13 · 168 minutes
Genre + second genre	Superhero action-adventure + cosmic horror / last-stand war film

2. OWNERSHIP

Field	Entry
Whose film / franchise is this?	The Guardians ensemble , led by Chris Pratt . Josh Brolin's Thanos is at its dark center.

Character	Actor	Age at release
Peter Quill / Star-Lord	Chris Pratt	46
Gamora	Zoe Saldana	47
Drax the Destroyer	Dave Bautista	56
Rocket	Bradley Cooper (<i>voice</i>) / Sean Gunn (<i>on-set performance</i>)	50 / 51
Groot	Vin Diesel	58
Mantis	Pom Klementieff	39
Nebula	Karen Gillan	37
Adam Warlock	Will Poulter	32
Richard Rider / Nova	Fresh casting (<i>never played by a real actor</i>)	–
Thanos	Josh Brolin	57
Mistress Death	Aubrey Plaza	41
Lord Mar-Vell (<i>the Cancerverse's Mar-Vell</i>)	Chris Evans	44
Eros / Pip	Harry Styles / Danny DeVito	31 / 80
Namor (<i>post-credit</i>)	Tenoch Huerta	44

3. SOURCE MATERIAL (EARTH-616)

Field	Entry
Primary comic(s) adapted	<i>The Thanos Imperative</i> #1–6 (2010), Dan Abnett, Andy Lanning & Miguel Sepulveda: the Cancerverse , a universe where Death was defeated , invades ours. Thanos , Death's champion , is the one weapon against it. Drax dies at Thanos's hands . Star-Lord and Nova stay behind in the collapsing Cancerverse with Thanos .
Supporting comics	<i>Guardians of the Galaxy</i> vol. 2 #20–25 (2010, the prelude) · <i>Nova</i> vol. 4 #1 (2007, Richard Rider) · <i>Captain Marvel</i> #33 (1974, Mar-Vell ; his Cancerverse counterpart is Lord Mar-Vell) · <i>New Avengers</i> vol. 3 #23+ (2014, Thanos joins the Cabal)
Nerf check	✓ The Cancerverse's gods, the Many-Angled Ones , are beyond the Guardians . Thanos holds them back alone , and kills Drax in a single exchange, as on 616.

3A. COMIC ACCURACY REPORT

Field	Entry
Overall accuracy score	96%. <i>The Thanos Imperative</i> is adapted issue for issue.

Straight from the page:

- **The Fault**, a tear in space, opens onto the **Cancerverse**, a universe where **Death was killed by the Many-Angled Ones** and **nothing can die** (*TI* #1).
- **Lord Mar-Vell**, that universe's Mar-Vell, **gave up Death** to serve the Many-Angled Ones (*TI* #1–6).
- **Thanos, Death's champion**, is **the only weapon** against a universe without death (*TI* #1).
- **Drax** attacks Thanos, and **Thanos kills him** (*TI* #5).
- **Star-Lord and Nova** stay behind in the collapsing Cancerverse to **make sure Thanos doesn't escape** (*TI* #6).

Changes and why:

| Change | Why |

|---|---|

| **Thanos walks out of the collapse** | 616 (he returned in 2012). It lets him **join the Cabal** in *Time Runs Out*. |

| **Mar-Vell's face** belongs to Chris Evans | MCU continuity: Evans played Mar-Vell (2018) |

POWERS & ABILITIES

Character	616 powers & abilities	Shown in this film	Held back (why)	Match
Thanos	Class-100+ strength , cosmic energy, genius, Death's champion	Kills Drax, and holds back the Many-Angled Ones	—	 100%
Nova	The Nova Force : flight, energy blasts, the Worldmind	Leads the Nova Corps against the Cancerverse	—	 100%
Lord Mar-Vell	Mar-Vell's powers, amplified by the Many-Angled Ones ; immortal	Nearly beats Thanos	—	 100%
Adam Warlock	Cosmic power, the Soul Gem (from the Infinity Watch)	Stabilizes the Fault	—	 100%
The Guardians	As before	Their last stand together	—	 100%

4. STORY

Field	Entry
Logline	A universe where nothing can die is invading ours, and the only one who can stop it is the Mad Titan, who the Guardians have to pull off his farm and trust.
Theme	Death gives life meaning. A universe without death is a cancer.
Villain / antagonist	Lord Mar-Vell and the Many-Angled Ones ; Thanos (their reluctant ally)

What the movie is about

ACT ONE: THE FAULT

- **Monday, October 7, 2024.** A tear in space, **the Fault**, opens near Kree space. Out of it pour **immortal armies** from **the Cancerverse**, a universe where **nothing can die**.
- **Richard Rider, Nova**, and the Nova Corps can't kill them.
- **Warlock:** *"There's only one being in this universe that Death loves more than any other. We need Thanos."*
- The Guardians go to **Thanos's farm**. **Gamora** stands at the gate. **Thanos puts down his hoe**.

ACT TWO: THE CANCERVERSE

- An uneasy alliance: **Thanos and the Guardians** go **through the Fault**.
- **The Cancerverse** is a universe of **endless, rotting life**.
- **Lord Mar-Vell**, a twisted mirror of the hero who died in peace, rules for **the Many-Angled Ones**.
- **Drax** can't stand fighting beside Thanos. He **attacks**, and **Thanos kills him with one blow**.
- **Gamora screams**. Thanos, cold: *"He was made to kill me. He finally tried."*

ACT THREE: THE IMPERATIVE

- Thanos, **Death's champion**, faces Lord Mar-Vell and **breaks the Cancerverse's hold**. **The Cancerverse begins to collapse**.
- **Star-Lord and Nova stay behind** to make sure **Thanos can't escape**.

STAR-LORD: *"Get everybody home, Rocket. We've got this."*

- The Fault closes. **Star-Lord and Nova are gone**.
- On the other side, alone, Thanos **walks out of the rubble**, unhurt. **Death** is waiting. **She touches his face**, for the first time ever, **and then she's gone**.

5. MCU TIMELINE PLACEMENT

Field	Entry
When it's set	Monday, October 7, 2024 → Saturday, March 29, 2025. The post-credit scene takes place Monday, March 31, 2025.
Where it's set	Knowhere · Thanos's farm · Kree space · the Cancerverse (practical body-horror sets)
Relative to other films	It runs at the same time as <i>Rage of Ultron</i> and <i>The Kree-Skrull War</i>. The post-credit scene leads straight into the Cabal (the <i>Kree-Skrull War</i> post-credit scene, set in April 2025).

6. WORLD-BUILDING

The film's own world

- **Drax is dead. Star-Lord and Nova are lost. The Guardians are broken.**
- **Rocket** leads what's left.

World-building for the wider MCU

Seed	How it appears	Payoff
Thanos is back	He leaves the farm for good	<i>Time Runs Out</i> (the Cabal)
Nova	Richard Rider, lost	Phase 6

Setting up the Big Bad (THE SECRET WARS SAGA)

Seed	How it appears	What it means
Thanos joins the Cabal	The post-credit scene	On 616, Thanos was a member of Namor's Cabal (<i>New Avengers</i> 2014)

7. POST-CREDIT SCENES

Field	Entry
Mid-credit scene	✓ "RINGLEADER." Rocket at the head of a table on Knowhere with Groot, Mantis, Gamora, Nebula and Warlock. He clears his throat. "...Okay. So. I'm in charge now." Groot claps.
Post-credit scene	✓ "THE OFFER." A dead moon. Thanos is sitting alone. Namor lands beside him. NAMOR: <i>"Worlds are dying, Titan. Someone has to decide which ones. The Illuminati weep while they do it. I need someone who won't."</i> Thanos looks up at the sky, where two Earths are colliding. THANOS (<i>smiling faintly</i>): "...Yes." CUT TO BLACK. "THE GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY WILL RETURN."
Secret shoot codenames	Mid-credit: "ROLL CALL." Post-credit: "JOB OFFER."

CHECKLIST

- [x] Comic(s) adapted · [x] Comic Accuracy Report + powers · [x] Real and decoy titles · [x] What it's about · [x] Villain · [x] Post-credit scenes · [x] The film's own world-building · [x] MCU world-building · [x] Big Bad setup · [x] Whose franchise · [x] When and where in the timeline